that enjoyed little confidence from within and outside the Congress party.[40] After initiating the New Economic Policy that shelved the socialist model and liberalised the economy, Rao went ahead and changed the template of Indian foreign policy. On Afghanistan, in particular, India took another u-turn. Willing to move beyond the confines of anti-Pakistan partisanship despite strained India-Pakistan relations, Rao put India's Afghanistan policy on a firmly conciliatory track in 1992.[41] Enunciated in what is known as the Rao Doctrine, India was to (a) 'deal with all Mujahideen groups without fear or favour and contact should be established with anyone and everyone willing to meet us despite the militancy of their Islamism'; (b) India should 'deal with whosoever was in power in Kabul and focus would be on cultivating a friendly government that was sensitive to India's vital interests and core concerns (sic)'; (c) India should 'deal strictly with the government in Kabul, no matter its proximity with Pakistan or its security agencies'; (d) India 'would neither arm any Afghan group nor ostracise any group —not even the Wahhabi group of Ittehad headed by Rasul Sayyaf'; and (e) India will 'focus on P-2-P [people-to-people] relations', build goodwill among all Afghans and 'meaningfully contribute towards Afghanistan's economic welfare,' within its limited scope.[42] And finally, unlike other countries that had shut their Kabul embassies in 1989, India was to retain its diplomatic mission as long as possible despite the anarchy.[43] Unlike what is seen today, India and Pakistan, despite the violence in Kashmir, discussed the Afghan situation regularly throughout this phase.

On 30 April 1992, two weeks after Najibullah's fall, India officially recognised the Mujahideen government. The very next day, Nambiar, on Rao's orders, met with the acting Afghan president Sibghatullah Mojadeddi (April–June 1992) and opened contact with all senior Mujahideen leaders and conveyed to them India's abiding interest in sustaining and nurturing friendship and cooperation with Afghanistan.[44] Soon after, on 15 May 1992, the government announced humanitarian relief and medical supplies worth Rs 160 lakhs and airlifted them to Kabul in July 1992. Additionally, 44,000 tonnes of wheat was also dispatched to Afghanistan on a grant basis. With air transit not being an option (for so much wheat), the shipment was sent to Bombay, from where it went to Orissa, and then all the way up to Russia. It was supposed to come down to Mazar-e-